Some Riddles in the Behavior of Gods and Sages in the Epics and Purāṇas

Ever since my school days when I began to read the Indian epics and the Purāṇas in Hindi, I have been puzzled by what appears to me to be far too numerous instances of the indefensible behavior of our most honored sages and saints in these classic sources. I have also wondered why my countrymen, by and large, have not attended to this aspect of these hallowed stories which are known by the majority of the literate and the illiterate Hindus in our country and have also been proudly repeated by our elders to their children for thousands of years.

So far as the readers and listeners of these stories are concerned, a possible explanation does come to mind. The Hindus with regard to this particular aspect of the subject matter have suffered and are still suffering from a psychological disability called scotoma. This consists of a sighted man never seeing what he does not want to see. For example, if my mother, who has wonderful eyes, should happen to hang in her prayer room a picture of Siva and Parvati actually in the act of coitus, no amount of effort on my part would succeed in showing it to her. She sees only Siva and Parvati in the picture and is simply unable to see anything else. But the problem still remains, the problem is on the part of the writers of these stories. Why would they write and publicize such gross sides of their own moral and spiritual sages and saints?

In this chapter I propose the following questions, and I would like to know which answer, if any, satisfies the demands of either the ancient or the modern Hindu mind. Are the few accounts cited below true in detail or are they all untrue? Should they not be deleted or declared to be shameful lies interpolated by unscrupulous writers or narrators in the past? Should these stories about Indian sages and saints be allowed to disfigure the pages of otherwise highly respectful sources of our moral and spiritual heritage? Can any other sense, if any, be made out of them? Was the moral